

GoHighLevel Setup Checklist

47 points, zero to launch | By Samme Samuel, CoreFlare Agency

The exact 47-point checklist I use to set up GoHighLevel accounts for clients from zero to launch.

How to use this checklist

Most GoHighLevel builds fail for the same reason. Someone opens the funnel builder before touching the foundation. Then leads land in a CRM with no fields, no pipeline, and no way to text them because the phone number was never registered.

Work this list top to bottom. The phases are ordered by dependency, not by excitement. Domains and carrier approvals run on their own clock, so they get submitted early even though nobody enjoys that part. Automation comes late, because automation is only as good as the data structure underneath it.

- **Do not skip ahead.** Every phase assumes the one above it is finished. Build workflows before your custom fields exist and you will build them twice.
- **Start the slow items on day one.** A2P/10DLC registration and DNS propagation are waiting games. Submit, then keep working.
- **Test as a stranger, not as the builder.** Phase 9 exists because you always find something. Always.
- **Save the finished build as a snapshot.** Client two should take a fraction of the time client one did. That is the entire point.

This document tells you *what* to configure and *why*. It deliberately avoids menu paths and button names, because the interface changes and a stale click-path is worse than no instruction at all. If you know what you are configuring, you will find it.

Phase 1 — Account & Sub-Account Foundation

Items 1–7. Get the container right before you put anything in it.

#	Item	Why it matters
1	☐ Create a dedicated sub-account for the client One client, one sub-account. Never build a client system	The sub-account is the isolation boundary for contacts, numbers, and access. Mixing two clients into one

	inside your agency account, and never recycle an old sub-account that still has test data sitting in it.	location is the mistake that ends relationships.
2	☐ Complete the business profile with real details Legal business name, physical address, support email, support phone, website. Use the client's actual registered information, not placeholders you plan to fix later.	These details flow into email footers, SMS compliance, and carrier registration. Wrong data here causes rejections downstream that take days to unwind.
3	☐ Set the correct business timezone Set it to where the client operates, not where you sit.	Timezone drives calendar availability, workflow send windows, and every date in reporting. Get it wrong and appointment reminders fire at 3am.
4	☐ Apply branding at the account level Logo, favicon, and brand colours set once so funnels, emails, and booking pages inherit them.	Set once, used everywhere. Skip it and you will restyle every asset individually, then miss one.
5	☐ Add users with role-appropriate permissions An individual login for every team member. Admin access only for people who genuinely need it.	Shared logins destroy accountability and break lead assignment. Individual users let you route, track, and revoke access cleanly when someone leaves.
6	☐ Define business hours and after-hours behaviour Set the real operating window, then decide explicitly what happens to leads arriving outside it.	Automation only respects business hours if you define them. Undefined hours means either midnight texts or leads sitting untouched all weekend.
7	☐ Connect billing and confirm plan limits Verify a working payment method for usage-based services and check the plan supports what you are about to build.	Messaging, phone numbers, and premium actions consume balance. A system that launches and then silently stops sending is worse than no system.

Phase 2 — Domains, Email & Phone

Items 8–17. Start this phase on day one. Approvals do not care about your deadline.

#	Item	Why it matters
8	☐ Confirm who controls the domain and DNS Identify the registrar and secure access, or a named human who has it, before you commit to a launch date.	This is the single biggest source of delay in every build. "We'll get you DNS access" becomes three weeks more often than anyone expects.
9	☐ Connect a domain or subdomain for funnels and pages Point it at the platform and confirm it resolves and serves pages correctly on both desktop and mobile.	Client-facing pages on a generic platform URL leak trust and complicate tracking. Branded URLs convert better.

10	☐ Set up a dedicated sending domain for email Configure the client's own sending domain or subdomain rather than relying on a shared default pool.	Sending reputation should belong to your client. Share a pool and you inherit other people's spam complaints.
11	☐ Publish SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records Add all three authentication records and confirm they validate before you send a single campaign.	Major inbox providers now expect authenticated mail. Unauthenticated sending gets filtered to spam or rejected outright.
12	☐ Verify the from-address and set a monitored reply-to Use a human-looking address and confirm replies land somewhere a person actually reads daily.	Noreply addresses suppress engagement and hurt deliverability. If a lead replies and nobody sees it, the campaign failed silently.
13	☐ Warm the sending domain before pushing volume Ramp sending gradually on a new domain instead of blasting the entire list on launch day.	A cold domain sending thousands of emails looks exactly like a spammer to filtering systems. Reputation is earned slowly and lost instantly.
14	☐ Provision the business phone number Buy a number in the right area code, or port the client's existing number if continuity matters to them.	Local presence lifts answer rates. Porting preserves an established number but takes time, so decide and start it early.
15	☐ Submit A2P/10DLC brand and campaign registration Register the business entity and the messaging use case with accurate details and realistic sample messages.	Unregistered application-to-person texting gets filtered or blocked by US carriers. This is not optional, and rejections cost days, so get it right first time.
16	☐ Add compliant opt-in language and automatic opt-out handling Every SMS capture point states consent clearly, and STOP requests are honoured without human involvement.	Consent is both a legal obligation and a registration requirement. Vague opt-in language is a leading cause of campaign rejection.
17	☐ Configure call routing, voicemail, and recording Decide where inbound calls ring and in what order, record a real voicemail greeting, and enable call recording with the disclosure your jurisdiction requires.	A tracked number that rings nowhere burns ad spend. The voicemail greeting is often a lead's first impression, and recordings are the fastest way to diagnose why calls are not converting.

Phase 3 — CRM & Pipeline

Items 18–23. The data structure decides what automation and reporting are even possible later.

#	Item	Why it matters
18	☐ Define custom fields before importing anything Map the specific data this business needs to qualify and serve a lead. Name fields consistently and resist inventing one for every passing idea.	Fields created after an import mean re-importing. Every field is also a field someone must maintain, so build the minimum that answers real questions.
19	☐ Design a tagging convention and write it down Use prefixes such as source-, status-, and interest- so tags stay sortable and self-explaining. Document it where the team can see it.	Untagged CRMs become unsearchable within months. Ad-hoc tags invented by three different people are functionally the same as no tags.
20	☐ Build the opportunity pipeline with clear exit criteria per stage Name stages after what the business actually does, keep it to roughly five to seven, and write one sentence per stage stating what must be true to move forward.	Fifteen-stage pipelines never get updated. And without exit criteria, two salespeople stage the same deal differently, which turns your conversion data into fiction.
21	☐ Set up lead source tracking on every entry point Ensure paid, organic, referral, and offline sources all stamp their origin onto the contact record.	You cannot cut wasted spend if you cannot tell which source produced the closed deals. This is the report clients ask for first.
22	☐ Import existing contacts from a cleaned, mapped file De-duplicate, standardise phone formats, and map every column deliberately before uploading anything.	Dirty imports contaminate the database permanently. Cleaning a spreadsheet takes an hour. Cleaning a live CRM takes weeks.
23	☐ Set lead assignment and ownership rules Decide who owns a new lead by round-robin, territory, or source, and make the rule fire automatically.	Unowned leads are unworked leads. "Whoever gets to it first" reliably means nobody does.

Phase 4 — Calendars & Booking

Items 24–28. Booked appointments are the outcome the client is actually paying for.

#	Item	Why it matters
24	☐ Create a separate calendar per meeting type A discovery call, a paid consult, and an onboarding session have different durations, different owners, and different rules.	One generic calendar forces the wrong duration onto the wrong meeting and makes reporting by booking type impossible.

25	☐ Connect each user's external calendar two-way Link the personal work calendar so outside commitments block availability and new bookings appear there instantly.	One-way sync is how you book a prospect into someone's dentist appointment. Two-way is the only safe configuration.
26	☐ Set availability, buffers, and daily booking caps Define genuine working windows, add buffer time between meetings, and limit how many bookings a day one person can receive.	Back-to-back calls with no gap means every call runs late. Buffers protect call quality, caps protect the person taking them.
27	☐ Set minimum notice and maximum booking window Block bookings fifteen minutes from now, and stop prospects scheduling four months out.	No-notice bookings get missed. Far-future bookings almost never show up. Two settings prevent both.
28	☐ Configure the booking form, confirmation, and meeting details Ask only the fields you need, state clearly what happens next, and make sure the video link or physical address is generated automatically into every confirmation.	Every extra form field lowers booking rate. And "where is this meeting?" fifteen minutes before start is a fully preventable no-show.

Phase 5 — Forms, Surveys & Funnels

Items 29–33. Capture assets are worthless until you know exactly where each submission goes.

#	Item	Why it matters
29	☐ Build capture forms mapped to your custom fields Every form field writes to a defined CRM field. No orphan questions that land nowhere.	Data captured into nothing is data lost. If a question does not map to a field, either map it or delete the question.
30	☐ Build qualification surveys for higher-intent offers Use multi-step logic to score or route prospects before they ever reach a calendar.	Filtering unqualified leads before the call is the cheapest hour you will ever give back to a sales team.
31	☐ Build the core funnel pages, plus policy pages Opt-in, thank-you, booking, and confirmation at minimum, built mobile-first and fast. Publish a privacy policy and terms, and link them from every capture page.	Most traffic is mobile, so a funnel that only works on desktop loses the majority of its leads. Ad platforms also reject pages without visible policies.
32	☐ Wire every capture asset to a specific destination Each form, survey, and page triggers a named workflow, applies a source tag, and creates the right record.	An unconnected form is a silent leak. Leads submit, nothing fires, and nobody notices until someone asks where the leads went.

33	☐ Install tracking and fire conversion events correctly Add analytics and ad platform tracking to funnel pages, and fire the conversion event on the real conversion, not on the page view.	Ad platforms optimise toward whatever events you send them. Send the wrong event and the algorithm confidently buys you the wrong people.
----	--	---

Phase 6 — Automation & Workflows

Items 34–39. This is where the system starts earning. Build these six before anything clever.

#	Item	Why it matters
34	☐ Build the speed-to-lead response workflow Fire an automated text and email within seconds of any new inbound lead, and notify the assigned owner at the same moment.	Lead interest decays fast. The business that responds first usually owns the conversation, and automation is the only way to be first every single time.
35	☐ Build the long-term nurture sequence A multi-touch sequence across email and SMS for leads who did not book, spaced across weeks rather than days.	Most leads are not ready today. Nurture converts the ones your competitor already wrote off.
36	☐ Build appointment confirmation and reminder sequences Confirm on booking, then remind at sensible intervals before the appointment, always with a one-tap reschedule option.	Reminders are the highest-return automation in the entire build. A reschedule link turns a would-be no-show into a rebooking.
37	☐ Build the no-show and cancellation follow-up Trigger an immediate, non-judgemental rebooking message the moment someone misses or cancels.	No-shows are usually scheduling problems, not interest problems. Most businesses never follow up and write the lead off entirely.
38	☐ Build the review request workflow Ask for a review automatically after a positive outcome, timed while the experience is still fresh.	Reviews compound into inbound leads. Asking manually means asking rarely, and only when somebody happens to remember.
39	☐ Add exit conditions and stop triggers to every workflow Replies, bookings, purchases, and opt-outs must remove a contact from all active sequences.	Nothing burns trust faster than a lead who already booked still getting "you haven't booked yet" messages. This is the most common build error there is.

Phase 7 — Conversations & Reputation

Items 40–42. Automation starts the conversation. Humans still have to finish it.

#	Item	Why it matters
40	☐ Route every channel into the unified inbox SMS, email, calls, and connected social messages all land in one conversation view tied to the contact record.	Channel-switching is where leads get dropped. One thread per person means nobody answers a question that was already answered elsewhere.
41	☐ Create saved replies and snippets for repeat questions Write reusable responses for pricing, availability, location, and the three questions this business hears every week.	Faster replies win more deals, and shared snippets keep the team's language consistent instead of improvised.
42	☐ Connect review platforms and define response handling Link the client's review profiles so new reviews surface in the system, and agree who responds, how fast, and what tone is used for negative ones.	Unanswered reviews read as an inattentive business. A calm, fast reply to a bad review often persuades readers more than the five-star ones do.

Phase 8 — Reporting & Dashboards

Items 43–44. Build the report that answers a decision, not the one that fills a screen.

#	Item	Why it matters
43	☐ Build the dashboard around the metrics that drive decisions Leads by source, speed to first contact, booking rate, show rate, pipeline value, and close rate. Leave the vanity metrics out.	A dashboard that answers "which source should we spend more on" is worth more than twenty charts nobody opens.
44	☐ Schedule a recurring report to the client Send the numbers on a fixed rhythm so the client sees results without having to log in and go looking.	Clients renew when they can see what they are paying for. Reporting they have to chase is reporting they stop reading.

Phase 9 — Testing & QA

Items 45–46. Never hand over a build you have not walked through as a stranger.

#	Item	Why it matters
---	------	----------------

45	☐ Run a full end-to-end test as a real lead Submit every form from a device and email address the system has never seen. Confirm the contact is created with the correct fields, tags, source, and owner, that the speed-to-lead message arrives on both channels, that a real booking produces real reminders, and that a deliberate no-show triggers the follow-up.	Every build has at least one broken link between components, and the only reliable way to find it is to become the lead. Testing from your own logged-in account proves nothing.
46	☐ Verify exit conditions, deliverability, and rendering Confirm replying or booking actually stops the sequence. Check that emails land in the inbox rather than promotions or spam, that SMS delivers on a live carrier, and that every page and email renders correctly on mobile.	A workflow that will not stop and an email nobody receives are both invisible failures. You only catch them by checking deliberately before launch, not after the client complains.

Phase 10 — Client Handoff

Item 47. The handoff is part of the build, not an afterthought.

#	Item	Why it matters
47	☐ Train, document, transfer access, and save the snapshot Record a short walkthrough of the daily workflow, document what was built and where the moving parts live, confirm ownership of the sub-account, domain, and phone number is settled in writing, and save the finished configuration as a reusable snapshot.	A system nobody was trained on gets abandoned within a month, and an ownership question nobody answered becomes an argument later. The snapshot turns this entire checklist into a repeatable asset instead of a one-off job.

That is the 47

Work it in order and you launch a system that captures leads, responds in seconds, books appointments, reminds people to show up, chases the ones who don't, asks for the review, and reports on all of it without anyone touching a keyboard.

Skip the foundation phases and you launch a very expensive contact list.

Want a second pair of eyes on your build?

I set up GoHighLevel accounts end to end — CRM, automation, cold email infrastructure, and lead generation systems for entrepreneurs and agencies.

Book a free 30-minute call, bring your specific setup, and I'll tell you what I would fix first.

Get in touch	
Email	selangwe19u@gmail.com
Book a call	https://calendly.com/selangwe19u/30min
Website	https://samme-samuel.coreflareagency.com/
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/in/samme-samuel-975a8b305

Samme Samuel — AI automation, GoHighLevel, and lead generation systems. CoreFlare Agency. Based in Yaoundé, Cameroon. Working remotely, worldwide.